

FREE 8-WEEK TRAINING PROGRAM

RUN STRONGER

Not another beginner 5k plan. Eight weeks of structured aerobic building, threshold work, and running-specific strength — for runners who've got the basics and want to stop plateauing (or getting hurt).

ALEX WATSON — BSc HONS · L3 PT · L1 S&C

WHY RUNNING MORE ISN'T THE ANSWER

Most free running plans give you one lever: run more, run faster, or both, and hope your body keeps up. That's how you plateau — or get injured. The runners who keep improving year after year aren't just running well; they're building the tissue capacity and movement quality to handle the training in the first place.

This program is built around one principle: **strength is a running session, not an add-on**. Every week pairs your running with targeted strength work aimed directly at the muscles and patterns that keep runners upright, efficient, and injury-free — calves, glutes, and single-leg stability, not generic gym work.

Who this is for: you can already comfortably run 5km and you're not brand new to running — you want a structured way to get faster and more resilient, not a couch-to-5k plan.

Structure: 3 sessions per week, 40-60 minutes each. Three phases:

PHASE	WEEKS	FOCUS
Base	1-3	Aerobic volume, easy-pace discipline, running-specific strength introduced
Build	4-6	Threshold and tempo work increases, strength loads progress
Peak	7-8	Race-pace sharpening, taper, final test

Pacing: "Easy" means conversational — if you can't hold a sentence, slow down. "Threshold" is comfortably hard, a pace you could sustain for about an hour if you had to. "Race pace" is whatever distance you're targeting for your test in Week 8.

Equipment: nothing beyond bodyweight and, ideally, a set of dumbbells or kettlebells. Every strength session can be done at home.

SESSION 1 – EASY RUN + RUNNING STRENGTH

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	30 min easy, conversational pace
Single-leg calf raises	3 x 12 per side
Glute bridges	3 x 15
Single-leg RDL (bodyweight or light DB)	3 x 8 per side

SESSION 2 – THRESHOLD INTRODUCTION

BLOCK	DETAIL
Warm-up	10 min easy + strides
Main set	3 x 5 min @ threshold effort, 2 min easy jog recovery
Cool-down	10 min easy

SESSION 3 – LONG RUN

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	50-60 min, easy and controlled — this is about time on feet, not pace

Strength sessions are short on purpose – 10-12 minutes tacked onto Session 1. Consistency beats volume here.

WEEK 2

BASE PHASE

SESSION 1 – EASY RUN + RUNNING STRENGTH

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	30-35 min easy
Single-leg calf raises	3 x 15 per side
Glute bridges (add pause at top)	3 x 15
Single-leg RDL	3 x 10 per side
Side-lying hip abduction	2 x 15 per side

SESSION 2 – THRESHOLD

BLOCK	DETAIL
Warm-up	10 min easy + strides
Main set	3 x 6 min @ threshold effort, 90s jog recovery
Cool-down	10 min easy

SESSION 3 – LONG RUN

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	55-65 min easy, last 10 min at a slightly firmer but still controlled effort

WEEK 3

BASE PHASE — TEST WEEK

SESSION 1 — EASY RUN + RUNNING STRENGTH

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	30 min easy (kept short ahead of the test)
Single-leg calf raises	3 x 15 per side
Glute bridges	3 x 15
Single-leg RDL	3 x 10 per side

SESSION 2 — 5KM TIME TRIAL

BLOCK	DETAIL
Warm-up	10 min easy + strides
Test	5km, all-out sustainable effort
Cool-down	10 min easy

Record this time — you'll repeat it in Week 6 and test again in Week 8.

SESSION 3 — LONG RUN

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	60 min easy

WEEK 4

BUILD PHASE

SESSION 1 – EASY RUN + RUNNING STRENGTH

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	35 min easy
Single-leg calf raises, loaded	3 x 12 per side
Bulgarian split squat	3 x 8 per side
Single-leg RDL	3 x 10 per side
Side-lying hip abduction	3 x 15 per side

SESSION 2 – THRESHOLD INTERVALS

BLOCK	DETAIL
Warm-up	10 min easy + strides
Main set	5 x 4 min @ threshold effort, 90s jog recovery
Cool-down	10 min easy

SESSION 3 – LONG RUN WITH PICKUPS

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	60-70 min easy, with 4 x 2 min @ moderate effort woven in, easy pace between

WEEK 5

BUILD PHASE

SESSION 1 – EASY RUN + RUNNING STRENGTH

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	35 min easy
Single-leg calf raises, loaded	3 x 15 per side
Bulgarian split squat	3 x 10 per side
Single-leg RDL	3 x 12 per side
Side plank with hip dip	3 x 10 per side

SESSION 2 – THRESHOLD INTERVALS

BLOCK	DETAIL
Warm-up	10 min easy + strides
Main set	5 x 5 min @ threshold effort, 90s jog recovery
Cool-down	10 min easy

SESSION 3 – LONG RUN WITH PICKUPS

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	65-75 min easy, with 5 x 2 min @ moderate effort woven in

WEEK 6

BUILD PHASE – TEST WEEK

SESSION 1 – EASY RUN + RUNNING STRENGTH

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	25-30 min easy
Single-leg calf raises	3 x 12 per side
Bulgarian split squat	2 x 8 per side
Single-leg RDL	2 x 10 per side

SESSION 2 – 5KM TIME TRIAL

BLOCK	DETAIL
Warm-up	10 min easy + strides
Test	Repeat the Week 3 5km time trial
Cool-down	10 min easy

SESSION 3 – LONG RUN

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	60 min easy

Compare against Week 3. This is where the strength and threshold work should be showing up in the numbers.

WEEK 7

PEAK PHASE

SESSION 1 – EASY RUN + RUNNING STRENGTH

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	30 min easy
Single-leg calf raises	3 x 12 per side
Bulgarian split squat	2 x 8 per side
Single-leg RDL	2 x 10 per side

SESSION 2 – RACE PACE SHARPENING

BLOCK	DETAIL
Warm-up	10 min easy + strides
Main set	6 x 3 min @ target race pace, 2 min jog recovery
Cool-down	10 min easy

SESSION 3 – LONG RUN, TAPER BEGINS

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	45-50 min easy — shorter than recent weeks, this is intentional

SESSION 1 — SHORT EASY RUN + LIGHT STRENGTH

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	20 min easy
Single-leg calf raises	2 x 10 per side
Glute bridges	2 x 12

SESSION 2 — SHAKEOUT

BLOCK	DETAIL
Run	15-20 min easy, 4 x 20s strides

SESSION 3 — THE TEST

BLOCK	DETAIL
Test	Race your target distance, or repeat the 5km time trial at full effort

Compare this against Week 3 and Week 6. Whatever the distance you tested, you've built the aerobic base, the threshold capacity, and the strength to back it up — and you know exactly where the next block needs to focus.

WEEK	TEST	TIME	NOTES
3	5km time trial		
6	5km time trial		
8	Final test / race		

WHAT NOW

YOU'VE DONE THE STRUCTURED VERSION. NOW MAKE IT YOURS.

This program builds real fitness in general terms. Coaching gets you a plan built around your actual pace, your actual schedule, and your actual weaknesses — adjusted week to week instead of fixed on a page.

BOOK A FREE CONSULT →

alexwatson444@gmail.com · @alexwatsoncoach · 07397 882264